CALF TRAINING PER LYLE MCDONALD

PAUSE, DON'T BOUNCE

IT'S NOT YOUR GENETICS — IT'S YOUR EXECUTION

01 MISTAKE NO. 1: BOUNCING

Your **Achilles tendon** is built like a spring: it stores elastic energy and releases it again — just like a kangaroo, whose tendon does **92% of the jump work**. When you **bounce** at the bottom, the tendon does the work instead of the muscle.

WITH BOUNCING	Muscle ~25%
WITH 2-SEC PAUSE	Muscle 100%

No other tendon in the body stores this much energy — for no muscle group does strict execution make as extreme a difference as it does for the calves.

02 THE PERFECT REP

Four steps that force your calves to do the work themselves.

STEP 1

2-SEC PAUSE

At the bottom, take an **absolute, dead pause**: count "1001, 1002" in your head. This lets the tendon's spring energy dissipate.

STEP 2

DRIVE UP

From the pause, push **explosively up** onto your toes — no swing, pure muscle force.

STEP 3

SQUEEZE

At the top, **consciously contract the calves hard** — hold briefly.

STEP 4

LOWER SLOW

Lower the weight under control, deep into the stretch — then start again at Step 1.

-20%
WEIGHT

Without the swing, your muscle suddenly has to do **all the work**. Cut your usual training weight by about **20%** — it's not a step back, it's the moment your calves get truly trained for the first time.

EXERCISE SELECTION

03 TWO MUSCLES, TWO EXERCISES

Your calf is made of two muscles with different fiber types — which is why they need **different rep ranges and tempos**.

STANDING CALF RAISE

KNEE STRAIGHT

6-10
REPS

Explosive
UP TEMPO

- Hits **gastrocnemius + soleus**. The gastrocnemius gives the calf its diamond shape and is mostly made of **fast-twitch fibers** *(Type II)* — it wants heavy, explosive sets.
- After the 2-sec pause at the bottom, **drive up explosively** — heavy sets are plenty, no need for 100-rep sets.

SEATED CALF RAISE

KNEE BENT

12-15
REPS

Slow
BOTH DIRECTIONS

- The bent knee takes the gastrocnemius out of play — **the soleus works in isolation**. It gives the calf its width and, as a pure postural muscle, is made of **slow-twitch fibers** *(Type I)*.
- Move **deliberately slower** — optionally hold a hard 2-second squeeze at the top as well.

04 FOOT POSITION: JUST NEUTRAL

~5%
DIFFERENCE

Turning your toes in or out to "target different parts of the calf"? In practice it makes only about a **5% difference** — negligible. Just let your **toes point straight ahead, neutral**.

! **REMEMBER**

Your calves aren't "stubborn" — they were just never trained properly. **2-second dead pause at the bottom, drive up explosively, squeeze hard, lower slowly** — with about 20% less weight. Bounce and you train your tendon. Pause and you train your muscle.